political alliance."[76] In subsequent declarations and joint statements, with the exception of the one issued in 2002, India and Russia did not even choose to mention the pledge of military neutrality.[77]

The loss of the external balancer and the simultaneous outbreak of the balance of payments crisis in the early 1990s provided a fillip to the process of rapprochement with China that India had initiated a few years earlier.[78] China had its own set of compulsions to pursue rapprochement with India at that time. The Tiananmen Square episode led to deep divisions within the leadership of the Chinese Communist Party, which was moreover concerned about its rule either collapsing like that of the Communist Party of the Soviet Union or becoming the object of the American policy of regime change.[79] Consequently, the Chinese leadership led by Deng Xiaoping chose to concentrate upon shoring up regime stability and reinforcing the Communist Party's legitimacy through both "diversionary peace" and sustained economic growth.[80]

These respective compulsions led India and China to sign two agreements in 1993 and 1996 for maintaining peace and tranquillity along the Line of Actual Control through the adoption of confidence-building measures to both prevent military incidents and deal with contingencies that may arise.[81] Subsequent agreements in 2005, 2012, and 2013 added new procedures and mechanisms to shore up the regime of mutual military restraint along the border.[82] Most significantly, in 2005, the Indian and Chinese Special Representatives arrived at an understanding on the political parameters and guiding principles for settling the boundary question.[83]

These efforts to maintain peace and tranquillity along the border and eventually move towards a final settlement of the boundary question were complemented by substantial progress in economic and political ties. China's emergence